



THE ACCIDENT
The AI171 crash is the first fatal crash involving a B787-8 Dreamliner

PHOTOS BY ANI

AIR INDIA ORDER BOOK

529 OUTSTANDING DELIVERIES

344 AIRBUS AIRCRAFT

185 BOEING AIRCRAFT

6 A350-900 INDUCED SINCE SEP 2023

35 B737-8 (SINGLE AISLE) INDUCED SINCE SEP 2023

“If given an option, Air India would perhaps like to advance the delivery schedule so that old aircraft can be rapidly replaced. This is imperative not just to enhance product quality, as new aircraft are fitted with several amenities, but also because they are fuel efficient,” he explains.

The AI171 crash is the first fatal crash involving a B787-8 Dreamliner. Air India has now been operating the Dreamliner for over 12 years, with the first plane inducted in September 2012, becoming the first Indian operator and the fifth airline globally to fly the Dreamliner.

The Tata Group acquired an ailing Air India in 2021 for \$2.4 billion, marking the airline’s return to its original founders after nearly seven decades of state ownership. Soon, Air India launched a five-year transformation plan to establish it as a world-class airline.

Mark D. Martin, CEO of Martin Consulting, flags maintenance lapses and unresolved issues at privatised Air India. “Delivery should not be a priority for Air India. The priority for Air India is to fix the airline,” he says.

In view of concerns related to poor on-board services and maintenance of aircraft, Martin says Air India functioned better under the government, saying, “Under the ownership of the government of India, Air India was 10 times better.”

Meanwhile, media reports have said that the engine of the crashed aircraft was changed a few months back, increasing insurance payout for Air India by ₹100 crore.

The Indian government has ordered a safety investigation of all B787-8/9. On the likelihood of grounding the Dreamliner aircraft, it is the prerogative of Boeing since Dreamliner is being operated by several other Indian airlines like SpiceJet and Akasa.

“It wouldn’t look appropriate to see Air India not flying Dreamliner where other airlines keep using them. Additional check ordered by the DGCA is a right step,” says Bhargava.

The US aircraft maker has been under the radar following whistleblower allegations of serious concerns about the structural integrity of the Boeing 787 Dreamliner—the company’s second-most scrutinised aircraft after the 737 MAX.

“Air India is not the only one flying the Dreamliner. Look at B737 Max. There were two fatal accidents, and Boeing asked all airlines operating this aircraft to ground them. However, once all the shortcomings were rectified, Boeing began delivering this aircraft and airlines the world over. SpiceJet and Akasa have taken delivery,” he says.

A team of FAA experts has also joined investigation with the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau under the civil aviation ministry. **BT**

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